

ON THE CD

TRACKS 26-28



- 26. Introduction
- 27. Full track
- 28. Backing track

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This month we look at how to liven up your solos with classic country-influenced thirds and sixths...

COUNTRY THIRDS & SIXTHS

GT RATING

MODERATE



Will improve your:

- Lick vocabulary
- Ability to play through key/chord changes
- Concentration and musical stamina

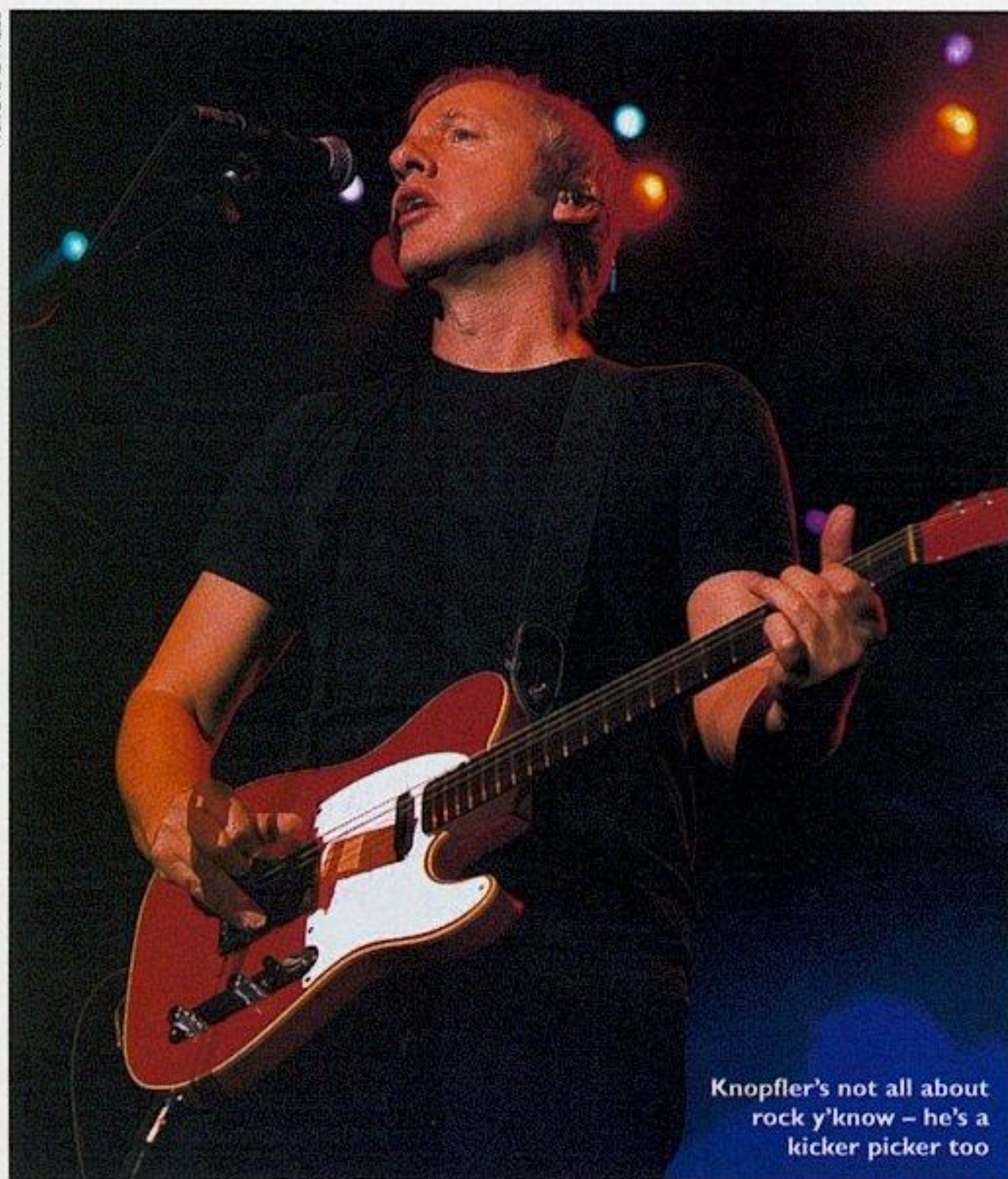
"Saying 'I'll feel it, man' may work... and it may not. Do you want to be a 'close, but no cigar kind of player?'"

YOUR GT TUTOR

■ LEE HODGSON
See p16 for more info on all the GT tutors



PICTORIAL PRESS



Knopfler's not all about rock y'know – he's a kicker picker too

These two intervals – thirds and sixths – are a staple of the country music genre, so here we're going to look at them in 12 different keys, in succession. Licks and fills based on these double-stops were common in the '70s and '80s, but you'll still find plenty on recent albums by Alan Jackson, Travis Tritt and George Strait, who all use renowned sessioneer Brent Mason. Mason's thirds and sixths lend more of a traditional flavour in the various styles of Chet Atkins, Chuck Berry, Albert Lee, Hank Marvin and Mark Knopfler. In contrast, modern country's other leading axe-man, Dann Huff, tends to favour fourths which lend his style a more rocky vibe.

Thirds and sixths are kinds of chord fragments. And who uses chords? Absolutely everybody, of course. So, let's take a look at what's on offer...

QUICK KEY CHANGES

The chord chart reveals that this lesson involves playing over a simple progression, I, V7, I... VI7, in every key. You'll remain in a certain key for three bars before

changing, via a secondary dominant chord. The brevity is intended – we want things to keep moving so you have to concentrate *all* the time.

By all means practice the various parts I've transcribed, but improvise too. You'll have to be on your toes – monitoring the chords constantly is vital. A good ear is essential, but it's not a fail-safe, as I'll explain later...

I've demonstrated thirds up to **bar 24** then sixths to the end. I've kept things simple, in the basic style of Chet or Knopfler. Also, notice that on the first beat of **bars 7 and 8** I use common tones: F# and A are the 3rd and 5th respectively of D, while the same two notes are the 5th and b7th of the upcoming chord, E. Understanding this is vital as it promotes confidence and eliminates hesitation, which can manifest itself as bad timekeeping or bad notes!

Another crafty way of dealing with changes is focussing your attention on the next change while considering how to modify the currently played note, so that it becomes part (of the harmony) of the next chord. You could call it voice leading but it's more about melody here and less to do with harmony itself.

To give an example, let's say you have a C chord and you're currently playing a G note (the 5th of C). The upcoming chord (via A7, which would let the G act as its b7) is D; the G note would, if left ringing or replayed, be the 4th of D (even numbered scale steps equate to non-chord tones and hence sound tense). What needs to happen to the G note then? Well,

SOUND ADVICE

CLEAN AND CLEAR'S HOW YOU FIND IT HERE

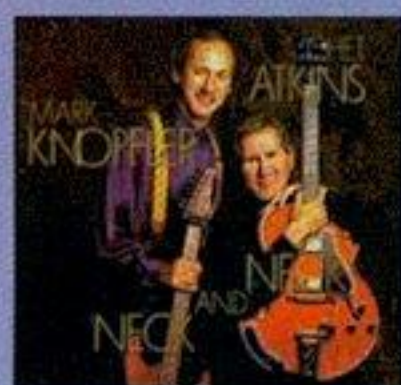
I SELECTED THE neck and middle pickup position on my Fret-King Corona guitar (11-58 Picato strings) via a RipCord into my Cornell Journeyman class A combo, which was set as follows:

Vol	Bass:	Treble:	Edge	Master
7.7	7	6.7	2.2	4

This was mic'd with a Shure SM58.

OPEN-STRING EXPONENTS

RECOMMENDED LISTENING



IF YOU LIKE SOME of the new country artists, have a listen to albums featuring session supremo Brent Mason; Alan Jackson's 'Greatest Hits' (1995), George Strait's 'Blue Clear Sky' (1996), or Mason's own album 'Hot Wired' (1997). For more in this style from Mark Knopfler and the late great Chet Atkins, try their duet album 'Neck And Neck' (1990) or Knopfler's debut solo album 'Golden Heart'.

TOP PICK

■ Knopfler/Atkins 'Neck and Neck' (above)

taking it up a tone to A (the 5th of D) would be okay but it's better to let (what would be) the 4th drop, by a semitone, to the 3rd of the (new) chord. Lots of theory.

EARS ARE NOT ENOUGH...

To put it another way, and satisfy the teaser from earlier, a good ear is not enough... Like when you hear a slightly dodgy note, quickly corrected a moment later? The player clearly has a 'good ear' but lacks forethought; poor overall awareness. Saying, "I'll feel it, man" may work... and it may not. Do you want to be a 'close, but no cigar' player? If not, be a stickler for correctness – if it sounds good then it is good. The opposite is also true! Enough...

You might want to modify elements in the lesson to add interest or complexity (connect thirds and sixths chromatically, for example). Whatever, see if you can get through the entire track without any mistakes!

GV

COUNTRY THIRDS AND SIXTHS

♩ = 94

1	C	G7	C	A7
5	D	A7	D	B7
9	E	B7	E	C#7
13	F#	C#7	F#	Eb7
17	Ab	Eb7	Ab	F7
21	Bb	F7	Bb	D7*
25	G	D7	G	E7
29	A	E7	A	F#7
33	B	F#7	B	Ab7
37	Db	Ab7	Db	Bb7
41	Eb	Bb7	Eb	C7
45	F	C7	F	F

NB

Observe how all key transitions which rise by a tone occur via the VI chord, while Bar 24 (*) effectively drops a minor third via the III chord; the change is made stronger because in each case a dominant 7th chord rises up a 4th (or drops a 5th) – the introduction of each new key via what would be its V chord is most compelling.

PRO TIP

UNDERSTANDING HOW 'common tones' work – using notes that are common to both the current chord and the upcoming one – will prove enormously beneficial to anybody's playing. In fact you may even start to kind of 'hear in advance'! That, and imagining what will become a chord tone of the next chord, too. It's not fortune telling, it's simply being prepared; being able to draw upon knowledge, points of theory and, ultimately, experience. Give it time!

KEY CHANGING THIRDS & SIXTHS

♩ = 94

mf
(Thirds to Bar 24)

CO CO

GT TAB

1 C G7 C A7

5 D A7 D B7

gliss

KEY CHANGING THIRDS & SIXTHS... CONTINUED

9

vib *gliss* *gliss*

CO MU CO CO

E B7 E C#7

13

gliss *gliss* *gliss tr*

CO Tr CO CO

C#7 G#7 C# Bb7

17

gliss *gliss* *gliss* *gliss*

Ab Eb7 Ab F7

21

gliss *gliss*

Bb7 F7 Bb7 D7

25

(Sixths to End)

gliss *gliss*

let ring CO CO

G D7 G E7

KEY CHANGING THIRDS & SIXTHS... CONTINUED

29

gliss gliss gliss

CO CO CO CO CO CO

A E7 A F#7

33

gliss

CO rake CO (CO) (CO)

B F#7 B A#7

37

gliss gliss vib

CO CO CO CO CO CO

D# A#7 D# B#7

41

gliss gliss gliss gliss gliss gliss

CO CO CO CO CO CO

E# B#7 E# C7

45

gliss gliss tr gliss

CO CO rake

F C7 F F